

Here is your guide to HAITI



Only hours away. You can be there to enjoy its year-round swimming . . . night clubs with songs . . . dances and drums . . . International Casino . . . creole and french cuisine . . . exciting spearfishing . . . historic monuments and exotic Mardigras.

Write today for your free copy of this booklet to:

Haiti Tourist Information Bureau
Official Government Agency
30 Rockefeller Plaza
New York, N. Y.

THE CRUEL SEA



by NICHOLAS MONSARRAT

\$4.00 at all bookstores

ALFRED A. KNOFF, Publisher

Did her husband's bankroll
hide a murderer's heart?

**FROM THIS DEATH
FORWARD** by ROBERT
BLOOMFIELD

A CRIME CLUB
Selection \$2.50

AUTHORS' OPPORTUNITY

You CAN have your book published. Our editorial, advertising and distribution facilities are at your service through our subsidy publishing plan. Send us your manuscript for review, or write for our free Authors' Manual.

COMET PRESS BOOKS—Dept. S.G
11 West 42nd Street, New York 36, N. Y.

moral attitude) were daily being degraded by hollow official rhetoric.

Although there is a tendency among the younger postwar writers to disregard their "little magazine" precursors, there can be no doubt about the spiritual and practical role they played in providing, if not a market, at least a meeting place and training ground. Another instance is that of *Solaria* published in the Twenties and Thirties in Florence (Italy, a recently united country, continues its vigorous provincial literary life which is not centralized as is the French), the review which later was transformed into the quarterly *Letteratura* and continues now as *Lettere e Arti*. For example, a writer like Vittorini, often cited among the representatives of the postwar revival, published his first stories in those early magazines, and also his first books, including "In Sicily": the magazines, following somewhat the example of the *Nouvelle Revue Française*, had a publishing firm attached, the typical "new writing" firm.

But other publishers as well, even among the most prominent and most commercially organized like Mondadori, had cordial relations with the *avant garde*. Mondadori's book series, *Lo Specchio*, is largely a new writing series. The distinction between the *avant garde* and other current literature is less sharp in Italy, perhaps, than anywhere else. One reason for this, of course, is also that what I call current literature does not have phenomenally high sales either and never represents a big commercial investment. Costs are much lower, too. In such a scantily industrialized literary scene there are no attempts at "producing" a writer the way studio publicity offices create a star. Perhaps the only relevant exception to this rule is Leo Longanesi, an extremely sharp and successful publisher (he published Berto's "The Sky is Red," a best-seller in Italy, and Flaiano's "Time to Kill," here translated as "The Short Cut"). Longanesi is also possibly the closest thing to an "editor," in the U. S. sense, that Italy has. In general, more scope is left to the Italian author to develop, undisturbed, his own intentions; after all *editore* in Italian simply means publisher, while the very concept of "editor" as literary hand and eye helping the author and representing the firm does not really exist.

THE smaller gap between the *avant garde* and current literature facilitates the existence of periodical anthologies of "new writing"; one of them is *Paragone*, published in Florence and resembling in shape the late *Horizon*;

another and bigger one, in fact one of really international scope, is the Italo-American *Botteghe Oscure* published in Rome.

If we keep this background in mind in considering the recent translations from the Italian, we see that we have here a number of novelists belonging to a long-neglected literature who not only now arouse a certain amount of curiosity and interest but also occasionally reach the best-seller lists and, in several instances, the inexpensive reprint circuit; and they are all writers whose attitude and formation have been artistic and not primarily commercial. At a time when some entertain doubts about the possibilities of literature's surviving as a popular art, this sign, within its limitations, can be taken as a positive portent.

If we look for the places, and for the training grounds, from which the new Italian writers emerge, there is another area we must watch besides the *avant garde* of the little magazines; in fact, a much wider one. This is comprised of a number of weekly magazines (like *L'Europeo* and *Il Mondo*), and by the *terza pagina*, or "third page," of the daily newspapers, traditionally devoted to literary articles and travel pieces. These institutions may have grown out of necessity; for obviously, Italian writers don't live on their books, and they must depend on newspapers and on periodicals that pay, when they don't depend on film scripts or (what is much rarer than in this country) on teaching. Whether the "third pages" and the weeklies grew out of necessity or out of public demand, or both, their literary consequences cannot be overestimated. The standards of a certain type of journalism are greatly raised. Novelists like Guido Piovene, Enrico Emanuelli, or Moravia himself have traveled broadly, and reported on their experiences in a literary tone which is acceptable to the better category of readers, which in fact contributes to the formation of such a category. Moravia's readers know that the *Corriere della Sera* brings them, along with the daily news, his short stories; and that *L'Europeo* brings them his weekly, extraordinarily intelligent film reviews. Flaiano, the novelist, is an editor of *Il Mondo* and its film critic. The daily *La Stampa* carries articles on American literature by Vittorini, on English literature by Mario Praz. The informality of the connection thus maintained by the writer with the public is indicated by a kind of half-literary, half-personal essay which is practically a specialty of the "third pages"; there are writers who keep a sort of public diary, like the novelist Vitaliano Brancati (whose

BUY U.S.
SAVINGS BONDS